

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Union Station revamp set to start

More money needed for Amtrak's complete renovation plans

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

Long-running plans to revamp Chicago's Union Station are poised to take a step forward in 2025, as Amtrak prepares to begin modernizing and boosting capacity at the commuter and intercity rail hub.

But the construction marks only one step of Amtrak's plans to overhaul parts of the station. The railroad, which owns Union Station, still needs to line up more funding for the rest of the work, a prospect that could face questions with a new presidential administration set to take office.

Plans for Union Station include rehabbing old, abandoned platforms that once served trains carrying U.S. Postal Service mail, returning them to service to add

capacity for more trains. Amtrak also plans to overhaul the station concourse to improve the way passengers move through the area, renovate and expand other platforms and bring them into compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act, and make other upgrades.

The nearly 100-year-old station, which serves Metra and Amtrak trains, was last renovated in 1991. The latest work is intended to help accommodate more passengers,

improving their flow through the station and allowing them to board and disembark trains quicker.

The work is set to begin next year with construction to return the former mail platforms to service, which could begin as soon as the spring, Amtrak spokesperson Marc Magliari said. Amtrak is also working on designing the revamped concourse, and plans later in the year to share initial ideas with the public, he said.

Construction outside Union

Station on Canal Street will also continue into the coming year. The street has been closed near the station since summer 2023 while the Chicago Department of Transportation rebuilds the road, and Amtrak has had to stop using one of the tracks below during the work, Magliari said. CDOT spokeswoman Erica Schroeder did not provide an estimated timeline to finish the project.

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GOP, Dems see signs of weakness in vote data

Closer look at Illinois shows softness in some unexpected places

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Donald Trump's Nov. 5 loss in Illinois was a foregone conclusion, allowing leading Illinois Democrats to focus on the nearby swing states of Wisconsin and Michigan in an ultimately unsuccessful effort to advance Kamala Harris' bid for the presidency.

But a closer look at the presidential election results in Illinois shows that a significant number of the state's Democratic voters also had their focus elsewhere — though not on Trump.

While Trump closed the gap in Illinois on a percentage basis compared with his last two runs for president, it wasn't because he won over large numbers of Democratic voters. His ostensibly improved showing came about in large part because Harris received nearly 410,000 fewer votes in Illinois than Joe Biden got in defeating Trump four years earlier, according to election results that were certified earlier this month.

Illinois Republicans, who have repeatedly been touting the November results as a sign of growing momentum for their beleaguered party, have been promoting largely illusory gains. Trump's vote total increased by a mere 2,188 votes from 2020, with a notable decline for the president-elect in downstate counties that have become the GOP's geographic base.

The results also continued a troubling tale for the state's Republican minority in failing to take advantage of Democratic disillusionment at the top of the ticket in downballot races.

To be sure, after losing Illinois by 17 percentage points in both 2016 and 2020, Trump's loss to Harris by 11 percentage points was a marked improvement — on a percentage basis.

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Dan O'Connor, the "Great Lake Jumper," makes his daily leap into Lake Michigan on Thursday during a below-zero wind chill. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

Lake sees its warmest November in 30 years

Climate change heats up Great Lakes with temps abnormally high for entire year

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

The frigid wind and single-digit morning air did not deter Dan O'Connor as he prepared Thursday for his daily plunge into Lake Michigan. Before stripping off his many layers, he tossed a thermometer into the water near Montrose Harbor, like he often does before a jump.

O'Connor — dubbed the "Great Lake Jumper" — peeked over the concrete platform. The instrument read 34 degrees. Satellite data put Thursday's lakewide

temperature closer to 45.5 degrees, almost 4 degrees above normal for that date.

Lake Michigan surface temperatures peaked at over 6 degrees above normal last month, the warmest they have been in November since 1995 when recordkeeping began at the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. In the first two weeks of December, daily lake temperatures hovered 2 to 4 degrees above the historical average.

The lake's average temperature has also been abnormally high

for this entire year, a condition mostly mirrored across the other Great Lakes. They are among the fastest-warming lakes in the world, a consequence of climate change that can have profound effects on the region's ecosystems and industries.

"The lakes have a memory. And we're starting to see in the data, that warm winter, that prior winter, does have an impact throughout the year and even into the following winter," said Bryan Mroczka, a physical scientist at NOAA's Great Lakes Environmental Research Laboratory.

During last year's meteorological winter, from December 2023 to February 2024, atmospheric temperatures in the area averaged 34.9 degrees, which was 6.8 degrees above normal, according to the National Weather Service. February was the warmest in Chicago and Illinois in nearly 150 years, and overall it was the city's fifth warmest winter on record.

Across the country, last winter also ranked warmest on record for the contiguous United States with eight states across the Upper

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Indiana readies first execution in 15 years

Man convicted a quarter-century ago of killing his brother and three other men would be state's first execution not initiated and performed by federal officials since 2009. Joseph Corcoran is scheduled to be put to death Wednesday. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Holiday rom-com season in full swing

Dozens of new movies and shows from Netflix, Hulu, Lifetime and Hallmark have recently appeared. Options range from those following tried-and-true tropes to a reality competition for future "Hallmark hunks." Check out a few recommendations. **Arts & Living**

New budget proposal has no property tax hike



Surrounded by staff members and aldermen, Mayor Brandon Johnson answers questions from reporters Friday following a Chicago City Council meeting at City Hall. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Johnson's latest plan would extend deadline for \$40 million in debt

By Alice Yin and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's latest plan to try to get aldermen to pass his budget for 2025 contains no increase in property taxes, thanks to a combination of cuts and a controversial idea to extend the deadline to pay back \$40 million in debt, according to aldermen briefed on the proposal Sunday.

Three sources present at the meetings with Johnson's budget team said his \$68.5 million property tax hike for next year has been zeroed out entirely, the

latest development in a remarkably fraught budget process that started with the first-term mayor breaking his signature campaign promise against raising that levy.

To make up for that gap, Johnson's new proposal calls for finding \$40 million from a move to "amortize line of credit in 2026," according to a copy of Sunday's briefing. That suggestion of a so-called scoop-and-toss maneuver will likely spark resistance from aldermen worried about what kicking the can down the road on its debt would do to the city's fiscal standing.

Johnson is set to try again to pass a budget package at a City Council meeting Monday after-

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